



PATH 19

Automation setups

A named setup that still runs a week later. Not 'I'll automate your company.'

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Who this is for

You can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire.

Time to first

7–21 days

Tools

First sale

One paid setup that still runs a week later.

Cash window

\$400–\$2,500 named setups

Leave this alone

Make, Zapier, n8n, or native Claude/ChatGPT connectors.

Open-ended retainers with no named job.

What this actually is

You sell a named machine. Lead form to draft reply. Weekly report to Slack. Invoice reminder that waits for a human. The name is the product. “I’ll automate your company” is how you vanish into their operations and never send a second invoice.

A setup is done when it still runs a week later without you in the Slack. You hand off a one-page runbook. You support it for 14 days. Then it is theirs, or they buy a new named package.

Why the name matters “Form to draft reply with your approval” is a thing a tired owner can say yes to. “AI operations overhaul” is a thing they will ghost. If you cannot write the before and after on one line, you do not have an offer. You have a hobby with logins.

Trust is the actual product If the machine can send mail without a human check, put a check in anyway until they ask to remove it. You are selling trust. The first time an automated message goes to the wrong person, they will not remember your cleverness. They will remember that you had no off switch.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire. You have built at least one of these for yourself. You can draw the flow on one page. You know what least privilege means, even if you learned it the embarrassing way.

You can do this if - You already use Make, Zapier, n8n, or a native Claude or ChatGPT connector for a real job, not a tutorial. - You can explain an off switch in two sentences. - You will write a runbook. People who hate documentation should pick a different path.

Skip this path if Skip it if you want an open-ended retainer with no named job. Skip it if you have never tested with fake data. Skip it if you need god-mode logins to feel useful. Skip it if the process has never been done manually — automating a fantasy workflow is how you spend three weeks debugging a job nobody actually does.

If you need cash this week, a brief or a productized service is faster. This path takes 7–21 days to a first paid setup because access, testing, and the runbook are the work.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you open Make: “Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750.”

Kai’s sentence is the default. Yours can swap the machine. Keep the shape.

What is in - One named flow, scoped to named tools, in writing. - A one-page diagram before you build. - Tests with fake data. - Human approval on anything that sends, posts, or charges, until they ask in writing to remove it. - A one-page runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, who to ping during the 14 days. - Fourteen days of support after handoff. Then a new package if they want more.

What is out Rewiring their whole company. Unlimited extra zaps. Sitting in their inbox as a junior assistant. Keeping their passwords in your password manager forever. If they want a second machine, it is a second quote.

What done looks like

Done is a setup that still runs on day 8 without you poking it. The client can pause it without calling you. The runbook is in a folder they own. Your access is the least they needed, and you have a calendar reminder to remove yourself after the support window if they do not need you.

The day-8 test You do not log in “just to check.” They send you a screenshot or a sample output from the week. If it failed silently, the runbook failed. You fix that inside the 14 days as support, then you write the failure into the runbook so it does not stay tribal knowledge.

Handoff, done - Diagram, runbook, and tool logins they control. - Off switch labeled in the first paragraph of the runbook. - Support end date in writing. Not “I’m around.”

Pricing

The cash window is \$400–\$2,500 for named setups. Kai charges \$750 for form-to-draft-reply with approval, runbook, and 14-day support. Copy that until you have a reason not to.

How to pick the number - \$400–\$500 if the flow is one trigger, one model call, one destination, and you already built it for yourself. First paid job only. Then move up. - \$750 for the default: form or inbox in, draft out, human approval, runbook, 14 days. This is Kai. This is you unless the tools are uglier. - \$1,200–\$2,500 if there are three tools, a messy existing sheet, or a compliance reason you have to move slowly. Still one named machine. Not a department.

What you do not sell Hourly “I’ll hop in the workspace.” A retainer that says “automations as needed.” A \$99 special that cannot pay for the runbook. Support after day 14 is a new package at a written rate, or they own the risk. Do not leave yourself on the hook because it feels kind.

The first 72 hours

Do not hunt a client on day one. Demo on your own accounts first.

Hour 1–6: pick one setup Form to draft reply is the cleanest first machine. You already understand email. The approval step is obvious. Build it on

your own form, your own inbox, a dummy customer name like “Test River.” Record your screen for eight minutes: form submit, draft appears, you approve, mail would send. Stop the recording before you philosophize.

Hour 7–10: price and a one-pager Write the sentence. \$750. Tools named: for example “Typeform or Tally, Gmail or Outlook, Claude or ChatGPT, Make or Zapier.” One page: in, out, approval, runbook, 14 days, what is not included. Payment: 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff.

Day 2–3: two offers Send it to two people with messy inboxes. Not ten. Two who have complained in your hearing. “You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week.”

If they want a different machine, you may swap the name only if you can demo that one too. Do not invent a custom empire because they sounded excited.

The path, step by step

Name the machine in one line. If it needs a paragraph, split it into two products and sell one.

Diagram on one page before you build. Trigger, tools, approval, destination, off switch. If you cannot draw the off switch, do not collect a deposit.

Scope the tools in writing. “Make plus Gmail plus Claude” is a scope. “Whatever we need” is how invoices die.

Take a deposit. Then request access. Least privilege: the form, the one inbox or label, the one sheet. Not their Google admin.

Build in a test environment. Fake names, fake emails you own, a dummy Slack channel. Never test by mailing their real customers.

Put a human check on anything that sends, posts, or charges. They can ask to remove it later, in writing, after they have seen a week of drafts.

Write the runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, where the logs live, what “looks wrong” means in one example, who you are until day 14.

Walk them through it live, twenty minutes, not a lecture. They pause it once with you watching. If they cannot pause it, you are not done.

Handoff in a folder they own. Invoice the rest. Calendar the 14-day end date.

Support for 14 days is break-fix and small clarifications, not new features. A new branch in the flow is a new quote.

Day 8: they confirm it ran. Day 14: you ask if they want a second named setup. If not, remove extra access you no longer need.

Only then write an SOP for yourself so the second client is faster. Do not productize a setup you have never kept alive for a week.

A worked example: Kai's \$750 form-to-draft

Kai helps a three-person studio that takes project inquiries through a Tally form. The form currently emails everyone, and replies happen two days later, or not. The owner asked Kai to “put AI on our intake.” Kai refused that sentence and sold a named setup instead.

The one-pager Kai sent Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Tally to Gmail draft (not send) via Make. Claude writes the draft from a 12-line studio voice doc. You click Send. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start.

The owner pays \$375. Kai asks for: Tally editor access, a Gmail label “Leads-drafts,” and a shared Doc with three good replies they liked last year. Not the whole Google org. Not the client's personal inbox.

Build week Monday: diagram. One page. Form submit → Make → Claude (voice doc + form fields) → Gmail draft in the label → human sends. Off switch: a Make scenario toggle, circled in red, screenshot in the runbook.

Tuesday: fake data. Kai submits “River Test / never-use-this@kai.example” four times. First drafts are too long. Voice doc gets a line: “Six sentences max. No ‘excited to potentially explore.’” Third test is boring and correct. That is the goal.

Wednesday: walkthrough, twenty minutes. Owner pauses the scenario and unpauses it. Kai watches. Owner files a real inquiry from a friend’s form. Draft lands. Owner edits one sentence and sends. Kai invoices the remaining \$375.

The runbook, what it actually says How to pause: Make, scenario “Lead drafts,” toggle off. Screenshot. How to know it broke: no draft in the label within ten minutes of a test submit. How to test: a form password Kai set, used only for tests. Who to ping until [date 14 days out]. What Kai will not do after that date without a new package: add Slack, add a second language, wire it to the CRM.

Day 8 and day 14 Day 8 the owner forwards three drafts that went out. One was too stiff; Kai tightens the voice doc inside support, not as a new product. Day 14 Kai removes Tally access, leaves the owner as Make admin, and asks if they want invoice reminders as a second named setup at \$750. Owner says later. Kai does not stay in the workspace “in case.” The machine still runs. That is the sale.

Copy you can actually send

The one-liner Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support.

The ask You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval so nothing sends until you tap it. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week.

The scope line, paste into the invoice In: one form, one draft destination, one model, human approval, one-page runbook, 14 days of break-fix. Out: extra tools, extra flows, sending without approval, retainers.

The runbook title How to pause [machine name].

How to know it broke. Support ends [date].

What you do not write “I’ll automate your ops.” “Unlimited zaps.”

“Set and forget forever.” “I just need admin access to everything.”

Those sentences are how this path becomes a second unpaid job.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Demo on your own accounts. Record it. Write the one-pager at \$750.

Offer it to two people with messy inboxes. Do not skip the off switch on your own demo. If you cannot pause your own scenario, you have nothing to sell.

Week 2 First paid setup. Diagram before you build. Fake data. Least privilege.

Runbook. Twenty-minute walkthrough. Calendar day 8 and day 14. Do not start a second client in the same week unless the first machine is already drafting.

Week 3 Support window. Break-fix only. Write down every

change you made; that list is either a runbook update

or a quote for setup two. Remove extra access at day 14.

Week 4 If the first machine still runs, you may offer a second

named setup to the same person or repeat the offer to two more. If

it does not run, you do not sell a second one. You fix your process.

The quality bar

The bar is a machine a non-technical owner can pause, and a week of drafts that did not embarrass them.

Before you call it shipped - Diagram exists and matches what you built. - Fake-data tests are saved. - Approval is on. - Runbook is one page, in their folder, with screenshots of the off switch. - They paused it once in front of you.

After Silent failure is a bug in your product, not a quirk of Zapier. If the flow can die without anyone noticing, add a simple alert: an email to them when a run errors, or a daily count in a sheet. Fancy observability is optional. “We would know by tomorrow” is not optional.

Do not ship a clever branch you cannot explain. Clever is how you get a 11pm text in week three.

What to count

Per setup - Did it run on day 8 without you? Yes or no. This is the first sale definition. - How many real drafts or actions in week one. Zero means the trigger is wrong or they stopped feeding the form. - Support touches in 14 days. More than five usually means the runbook is thin or you sold a process they do not actually run.

After three setups On-time handoff rate. Machines still running at day 30 — ask once, do not babysit. Average fee. If you are stuck at \$400 after three, you are discounting the runbook away.

Ignore how many modules the scenario uses. Clients do not buy module counts. They buy a named job that does not catch fire.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“Can’t they just turn on ChatGPT in the inbox?” They can turn on a lot of things. They hired you so it drafts in their voice, waits for approval, and can be paused. Native buttons without a runbook are how a junior sends a wrong quote at 6am.

“\$750 feels high for a zap.” They are not buying a zap. They are buying design, least privilege, tests, a runbook, and two weeks of you on the hook. A \$20/month tool with no owner is cheaper and worse.

“They want it to send automatically.” Not on day one. Run a week of approvals. If they still want send-without-check, get it in writing, add a holdout (never mail a list they did not just submit), and keep the off switch obvious.

“I need admin access to do it right.” You need the least access that makes the named machine work. Admin access is how you become the person who “also” resets everyone’s 2FA. Refuse god-mode.

“What if it breaks after day 14?” They have the runbook. They can pay for a new package. You may sell a \$150 check-in. You may not pretend you are on call forever because you feel responsible for software they own.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

What feeds a first automation job A productized service client who is drowning in a form. A local business you already wrote posts for. Yourself — the demo on your accounts is the sales asset. Cold “automation agency” ads are not how a kitchen-table operator gets job one.

What a living setup feeds - A second named machine for the same client, quoted separately. - A custom project setup (path 20) if they also need the model configured, not just the pipes. - Notes that become a playbook or a template for a narrower audience, later, after you have done it three times. - Definitely not an open retainer in week two.

Keep the machine named. The minute you become “our automation person,” you are on a salary they forget to pay.

Mistakes that kill this path

God-mode logins. No off switch. Automating a process that has never been done manually. Leaving secrets in a shared doc. Those still kill it.

The rest - Starting to build before the diagram and the deposit. - Testing on real customers. - Skipping the approval step to look advanced. - A runbook that is a 19-page novel. One page. Screenshots of the toggle. - Support that quietly becomes new features. - Staying in their workspace after day 14 “just in case.” - Quoting one price for “all the zaps they might want.”

If a password lives in a Google Doc titled “logins,” you have already failed the quality bar. Use a password manager they own, or sit with them while they type it.

Tools — only what you need

Pick one automation tool and get good at it. Make, Zapier, or n8n. Native Claude or ChatGPT connectors are enough for some jobs and better when the client already pays for them.

The rest of the stack A form (Tally, Typeform, native). An email box or Slack channel they already live in. A Doc for voice and the runbook. Loom or a phone recording for the walkthrough. Stripe for the deposit.

Access Least privilege. Shared folders they own. No personal Gmail of yours in the middle of their lead flow — if you leave, the machine should not.

Do not add yet Do not sell them a new CRM as a prerequisite. Do not rebuild their website to “capture leads properly” unless they paid for that as a different job. The named setup uses what they already click.

Checklist

Machine named in one line

One-page diagram includes the off switch

Tools listed in the quote

50 percent deposit before access

Least privilege, not admin

Fake data tests saved

Human approval on send/post/charge

Voice or rules doc they can edit

Runbook: pause, broken, logs, support end date

They pause it once in front of you

Handoff folder they own

Day 8 check: it still ran

Day 14: extra access removed

New features = new quote

No secrets in a shared Doc

FAQ

Make, Zapier, or n8n? Whichever you can demo this week on your own accounts. Do not learn a new tool on their dime. If they already pay for one, prefer that.

What if they do not have a form? Then the named setup is not form-to-draft. Sell a different named machine, or a smaller job to stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. Do not wander.

Do I include the Zapier bill in my fee? No. They pay their tool bills. You say that on the one-pager. Your \$750 is design, build, runbook, 14 days.

Can I keep access so I can “watch it”? Not after day 14 unless they buy a check-in package. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops.

What if the model writes a bad draft? That is why approval exists. Tighten the voice doc inside the 14 days. If they want a whole new tone for a second brand, that is a new quote.

Is \$750 too much for a first client who is a friend? Charge \$500 once if you need a case, then \$750. Free is how friends get a machine you cannot afford to support.

Should I sell a monthly retainer? Not until several named setups have survived day 30. Even then, name the hours and the machines. “Retainer for automations” is the leave-this-alone line.

What if they want Slack, email, and the CRM in week one? That is three machines or a \$2,500 scope with a written diagram. Default to one flow. You can stack later.

How do I handle API keys? In their account. Not in yours. Not in a chat log. If a key leaked into a screenshot, rotate it before you go to bed.

When is the first sale “real”? When the setup still runs a week later. A demo on your laptop is not a first sale. Kai’s first sale was the studio’s drafts on day 8.